INTRODUCTION · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

AWS Certified Machine Learning Engineer

Associate. Exam code MLA-C02. A complete, original preparation course.

EXAM **MLA-C02** QUESTIONS **85 in 170 min** PASS **720 / 1000**

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Every explanation here comes from **AWS documentation**. Not one question is recycled.

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What the exam validates

- **Prepare data.** Ingest, transform, validate for both ML and AI modeling.
- **Develop models.** Train, tune, and evaluate. Traditional models **and** foundation models.
- **Deploy and orchestrate.** Endpoints, CI/CD, and now agentic workflows.
- **Operate and secure.** Monitor drift, control cost, lock down access.
- Not tested: designing full end-to-end architectures, or setting ML strategy.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> This is an operations exam with machine learning as its subject. Building is only a quarter of it.

This certification is aimed at you if

- You build or operate ML systems in production and want the credential to match.
- You are a data engineer, backend developer or DevOps engineer moving into ML.
- You are a data scientist who now owns what happens after the model is trained.
- AWS expects **one year with SageMaker AI and Bedrock**, plus one year in a related role.
- There are **no formal prerequisites**. Nothing stops you booking it today.

> ON THE EXAM
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> New to AWS entirely? Cloud Practitioner or AI Practitioner first will save you time overall.

What you will sit

	DETAIL
Questions	85 total. 50 are scored, 15 are unscored and unmarked
Duration	170 minutes
Formats	Multiple choice, and multiple response
Pass mark	720 out of 1000, on a scaled model
Scoring	Compensatory. You pass overall, not each domain
Guessing	No penalty. An unanswered question scores as incorrect
Delivery	Pearson VUE test centre, or online proctored

ON THE EXAM

170 minutes across 85 questions is exactly two minutes each. Module 39 covers the time strategy.

Four domains, and how they are weighted

DOMAIN	WEIGHT
Domain 1 - Data Preparation for ML and AI	28%
Domain 2 - ML Model and Foundation Model Development	24%
Domain 3 - Deployment and Orchestration of ML and AI Workflows	24%
Domain 4 - Operating, Monitoring, and Securing ML and AI	24%
Everything after model development	48% - almost half

ON THE EXAM

The marker on the left edge of every slide shows which domain that content belongs to.

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MLA-C01 or MLA-C02?

MLA-C01, THE OLD VERSION

Retiring

- English ended 28 September 2026.
- Japanese, Korean, Simplified Chinese run until 14 January 2027.
- 65 questions, 130 minutes.
- No generative AI, RAG or agent content.

MLA-C02, THIS COURSE

Current

- Beta from 29 September 2026.
- General availability 14 January 2027, all languages.
- 85 questions, 170 minutes.
- Adds GenAI, RAG, agents and responsible AI.

IF YOU ARE ON THE OLD EXAM

Sitting C01 in one of the three remaining languages? Watch module 40 as well. It covers the differences.

The update added thirty-eight skills

- **Generative AI.** Bedrock model selection, fine-tuning, distillation, prompt engineering.
- **RAG end to end.** Chunking, embeddings, vector stores, reranking, retrieval accuracy.
- **Agentic AI.** Agent deployment, state management, versioning, coordination failures.
- **AI economics.** Token cost, embedding compute, vector storage.
- **Responsible AI.** Bedrock Guardrails, sensitive data safeguards, pipeline scanning.

> ON THE EXAM
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> No new domains were added. The additions were folded into the four that already existed.

Some examinable services are closed to new customers

- **Model Monitor, Clarify, Ground Truth, Debugger, A2I** and four more moved to maintenance.
- New customers cannot sign up as of **30 July 2026**. Existing users are unaffected.
- SageMaker Profiler is **sunsetting**. Ground Truth Plus **ended** in June 2026.
- They remain in the exam guide, so they remain examinable.
- This course teaches the examinable answer **and** names the replacement.

> ON THE EXAM
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> If you open the console to practise and cannot create Model Monitor, nothing is wrong with your account.

Almost every question is asking **which stage of the lifecycle** you are standing in.

The same four movements, every time

01

Teach

The concept, and what AWS actually documents about it.

02

Compare

The look-alike options placed side by side.

03

Tiebreak

The one word or constraint that separates them.

04

Decide

Four worked scenarios. You answer first, then I walk it.

ON THE EXAM

The tiebreaker slides are the highest-value ones in the course. They are what you revise the night before.

Pause. Commit. Then watch the walkthrough

- **Every scenario pauses.** Commit to a letter out loud or on paper before it resumes.
- Watching a walkthrough without answering first teaches **almost nothing**.
- Being wrong and finding out why is what moves your score. It is meant to sting slightly.
- For wrong answers, ask why **all four** options are right or wrong, not just the key.
- That last habit generalises to questions you have never seen. Recognition does not.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> This is the whole method. Everything else is detail.

A plan that beats rewatching

1. Watch in order. Later modules assume earlier vocabulary.
2. Take practice exam one after the teaching modules. Score it **by domain**.
3. Rewatch only your weakest domain. Then exam two.
4. Leave several days, then exam three. Recall after a gap predicts a pass.
5. Night before: confusion pairs and the maintenance map. Nothing else.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Revising what you already know feels productive because the scores stay high. It moves nothing.

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Forty-four modules, weighted like the exam

SECTION	MODULES
Foundations	00 to 01
Domain 1 - Data Preparation for ML and AI	02 to 11
Domain 2 - ML Model and FM Development	12 to 19
Domain 3 - Deployment and Orchestration	20 to 28
Domain 4 - Operating, Monitoring, Securing	29 to 36
Exam skills and confusion pairs	37 to 40
Practice exams, 60 questions	41 to 43

ON THE EXAM

Teaching time matches the published domain weights to within a tenth of a point. That is deliberate.

Verified against AWS documentation in **September 2026**. Check the exam guide before you book.